The Kryptonite Kid

By Joseph Torchia

JERRY: **(Pg 8-11)** Dear Superman, Last night at supper I decided to tell my mom how Superman might be writing me a letter pretty soon. And my mom said . . .

MOM: There isn't any superman. He's just make believe like Goldilocks and Little Red Riding Hood.

JERRY: And I said that was really DUMB. Little Red Riding Hood is just a story and you're a ***real*** person except you're a ***SUPER*** person which is even better. That's what I said, you should have heard me. Right in front of my dad and everybody. *(yelling to family)* THERE IS TOO A SUPERMAN BECAUSE I CAN SEE HIM ON TELEVISION!

My dad pushed the chair back and stood up and I thought he was gonna hit me with the newspaper. Usually he hits me with his hand, but this time he picked up the newspaper, opened it up and put it right in front of me and said, "Who's that?" It was a picture of you, Superman.

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DAD: See that? You can read. It says Superman is dead, it says he shot himself in the head." *

JERRY: I tried to read it, but my eyes were all watery and my nose was running, and I knew he was gonna hit me. I knew it. But I didn't care! I told him he was a LIAR and that that was the STUPIDEST thing I ever heard in my life! Nothing can kill Superman except Kryptonite. . . And that's when he hit me.

DAD: That guy on TV is just an actor. There isn't a Superman. There never was and there never will be.

INTRODUCTION

*Jerry Chariot's often escapes his confusing and strict Catholic childhood by immersing himself in Superman comics. The problem is that Jerry believes the Man of Steel is **real**. After all, if God is real, why can't Superman be real too?*

But when Jerry decides to literally fly away from his troubled family, Sister Mary Justin, and the Catholic religion, he discovers the cost of his misguided devotion, and more surprisingly, how true heroism can come from the most unlikely places.

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JERRY: **(Pg 15-17)** Dear Superman, Pretty soon we're gonna be making our First Holy Confession. We have to learn

about sins and how to confess them. The other day, while we was in church, I couldn't think of very many sins, so I decided to read the latest SUPERMAN #163. I was on page 4 when . . .

SISTER MARY JUSTIN: *(whispering really loud)* Jerome!

JERRY: I knew I was in for it.

SISTER MARY JUSTIN: *(out loud – very loud)* SUPERMAN IN CHURCH! IN CHURCH! YOU BETTER PRAY YOU DON'T GET HIT BY A CAR WHEN YOU LEAVE BECAUSE IF YOU DIE YOU'LL GO STRAIGHT TO HELL!

JERRY: She said [it] Like I had committed a Moral Sin which is the worst kind there is. It's kinda like Green Kryptonite and it means you're going to Hell. And let me tell you, Superman, Hell is a lot like Krypton on the day it blew up in GIANT SUPERMAN #22, page 10. It's all hot and red and burning. And you sweat a lot and your skin starts on fire and you want to die but you can't because you're already dead.

SISTER MARY JUSTIN: SUPERMAN IN THE HOUSE OF GOD!

JERRY: And she grabbed the comic book and teared it up and threw it in the air. She said she was gonna tell the Principle (sic) and call my mom and dad and I better

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pray. **(Pg 20)** So far I have 677 Hail Marys and 12 Our Father Who Art in Heavens. Which is a LOT!

(Pg 18) PS: You're just as good as GOD and so I think it's OK if you're in his house. I know you wouldn't mind if God was in your Fortress of Solitude. I just wanted to tell you in case you felt bad about what Sister Mary Justin said.

(Pg 60-61) Dear Superman, My mom's got this towel which is REAL old so I figured she won't miss it. I got a Magic Marker and put an S on the back of it – that stands for Super Jerry. I hope you don't mind. And . . . And . . . And. . . I usually climb to the second branch [of Old Lady Holbrook's apple tree] but this time I climbed to the third! I put my hands out in front of me and Robert, **(Pg 17)** he's my bestfriend, said . . .

ROBERT: **(Pg 61)** ARE YOU READY? I'LL COUNT TO 3 OK?

JERRY: And I flew REAL good, Superman. Only I didn't land too good and that's why my foot still hurts. I can't tell mom because she'll get mad. I wasn't supposed to be up that high. Especially with a cape on. But you just wait, Superman. I'll do it. You'll see. – *Getting Super, Jerry*

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(Pg 105-107) Dear Superman, my mom got almost as mad as my dad did. He didn't even wait till we got in the house. He just held me up in the air and kept hitting and hitting me. Mom was yelling . . .

MOM: STOP IT STOP IT YOU'LL KILL THE BOY!

JERRY: And mom was crying like I was.

DAD: NOW GET IN THE HOUSE!

JERRY: I could hardly even walk. *(beat)* My mom and dad kept fighting long after I went to bed.

MOM: YOU DON'T HAVE TO BEAT HIM LIKE THAT!

DAD: I'LL DO WHAT I DAMN WELL PLEASE! SHUT UP BEFORE I HIT YOU TOO!

JERRY: And my dad hit her. Real hard. *(beat)*That's why I couldn't sleep. I really hate him, Superman. More than Luthor or The Joker or ANYBODY. If he ever hits my mom again . . .

(Pg 124-125) Dear Superman, I'm gonna fly, Superman, I'm REALLY gonna fly! I'm gonna jump off the roof of my apartment building and then fly all the way to Holy Redeemer Church and get my First Holy Communion in front of everybody. Robert said I should way until AFTER we get Communion and this way if something goes wrong

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then I'll go to Heaven for sure. But I want to do it when EVERYBODY'S gonna see me. Boy are they gonna be surprised!

(Pg 128) Dear Superman, Sister Mary Justin was teaching us how to write poems. She told us to go home and write a poem about somebody we love a LOT like our mom or the Pope. **(Pg 133)** Well, I just got finished and it's called "TO SUPERMAN" -- Roses are red / Your outfit is blue / I like you better / than Jesus the Jew. Amen *(beat)*

(Pg 137) Sister Mary Justin hated it so much she said she was gonna ask Father Ponti to say that I can't get my First Holy Communion until NEXT year because I'm the WORST pupil she ever had in her life. *(beat)*

(Pg 140) My mom has been crying all afternoon. She's so ashamed. I never seen her cry like that before – with such sadness. Because of ME. *(long silence)*

(Pg 156-157) Dear Man of Steel. [Today] I was standing on top of my apartment building and everybody was watching me and I had on my cape and I felt so good, and I felt so beautiful. I was just getting ready to leap in the air, when all of a sudden my mom yelled . . .

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MOM: LOOK! UP IN THE SKY!

BROTHER: IT'S A BIRD!

NEIGHBOR GIRL: IT'S A PLANE!

ROBERT: NO -- IT'S SUPERMAN!

JERRY: **(Pg 170-171)** [Well, really. . .] EVERYBODY down below was running around and screaming and pointing up at me.

MOM: GODDAMNIT, JERRY, GET DOWN HERE!

BROTHER: AWW, HE'S CHICKEN ANYWAY!

JERRY: And I heard my dad's feet pounding up the steps, climbing up on the roof, rushing toward me. Quickly! Urgently!

MOM: BE CAREFUL! OH MY GOD! MY GOD!

JERRY: And then I jumped, and **(Pg 173)** I found out I couldn't fly. **(Pg 177-178)** I was falling through the air. But somebody was holding me in his arms. At first I thought it was [you] Superman -- that [you] had swooped down and tried to save me. But it wasn't. *(beat)* It was my dad.

[When] he realized he couldn't reach me, he leaped. Like Superman. He caught me in mid-air. **(Pg 176)** He held me in his arms real tight, almost hurting me. He was crying. My dad was crying! **(Pg 177-178)** And he fell with me, in front of me, saving me from the sidewalk. But not the siren. *(long beat)* [When] I woke up, Sister Madonna was standing there, crying. Looking at me. Praying.

SISTER MADONNA: God forgive him. God forgive this child, this child.

JERRY: She was like a guardian angel. I wanted to tell her that I didn't hurt, that I was numb, I couldn't feel anything. But words wouldn't come out. I felt like somebody was sitting on my throat. I heard her **(Pg 159)** whisper to somebody that I broke my neck poor child. But I don't believe it. *(long beat)*

I don't believe in ANYTHING anymore, Superman. Not even you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

NIETOC
KS State Qualifier
NJ State Finalist

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***** *George Reeves, the actor who played Superman in the 1950s television series Adventures of Superman, died by suicide in 1959.*
More information can be found here:
https://biographics.org/george-reeves-the-mysterious-death-of-superman/

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